Riverton Urban Forest Assessment 2025

Prepared by the Riverton Parks and Forestry Division for the City Council, March 2026.

Summary

Riverton's tree canopy covered 25.8% of the city in 2025, down from 31.4% in 2016. Over ten years the city removed 7,560 street trees and planted 4,370. Removals outpaced plantings every year.

Where the shade went

The losses are not even. The Eastside and Millbrook neighborhoods lost the most canopy: Eastside fell from 22% to 14%. Surface temperatures on Eastside blocks ran 9 degrees Fahrenheit hotter than on shaded Northgate blocks on the hottest afternoon of July 2025.

Most removals were mature oaks and maples lost to storms, emerald ash borer, and utility work. A young tree takes about 15 years to cast the shade of the tree it replaces.

What it costs

Riverton's trees remove an estimated 410 tonnes of air pollution a year and intercept 180 million gallons of stormwater. The division values these services at $6.2 million a year.

Options

A planting program of 1,500 trees a year, with three years of watering, would cost $2.1 million a year and return the canopy to 30% by 2040. Planting first on Eastside and Millbrook would cool the hottest blocks soonest.

Recommendation

The division asks the Council to fund 1,500 plantings a year for five years, beginning with the 2027 budget, and to require one replacement tree for each tree removed for utility work.